SiteScanly

Broken Links, 404s and Redirects: A Plain-English Guide

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Introduction

If your website has broken links, missing pages, or buttons that lead nowhere, it can make your business look neglected before you even realise there is a problem. This ebook is a plain-English guide for small business owners and sole traders who want to understand broken links, 404s, redirects, and missing files without technical jargon.

You will learn what to look for, why it matters, and how a simple website health check can help protect trust, enquiries, and your online reputation.

In this guide, we will cover:

01 What broken links actually are

02 404 pages and missing content

03 Redirects and old URLs

04 Broken images and missing files

05 A simple monthly link-check mindset

06 How SiteScanly can help

01

What broken links actually are

Broken links are exactly what they sound like: links that no longer take a visitor to the right place. Instead of leading to a page, file, image, or action that works, they send someone to something missing, outdated, or broken. Many owners assume this only applies to obvious page errors, but the reality is wider than that. A website can look polished on the surface while still hiding small link problems that make the experience feel untidy underneath.

These issues often build up quietly. A page may be renamed during a redesign. A button may still point to an old URL. A blog post may link to an external article that no longer exists. A download may have been replaced, while the original file link was left behind. None of that feels dramatic when it happens, but the effect adds up over time. Visitors do not usually stop to think about why a link failed. They simply notice that part of the site does not work as expected.

That is why the phrase 'broken links on my website' matters. It is not just a technical question. It is really a question about trust, ease, and whether your website still supports the way people use it today.

What makes this tricky for small business owners is that broken links often hide in places you do not revisit very often yourself. You may rarely click an old blog post, test an older download, or follow every button on every page. That is why these problems can sit unnoticed for weeks or months. They are easy to miss internally, but still obvious to a visitor trying to use the site properly.

Broken links often include:

- Internal links between your own pages
- External links to other websites
- Broken buttons and calls to action
- Missing downloads, PDFs, or forms
- Images or files that no longer load

A good website health check should treat all of these as part of the same wider picture. For a low-tech small business owner, the key point is not the technical label. It is whether a visitor can move through the website smoothly, find what they need, and feel confident enough to keep going. That is why even small link problems deserve attention.

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404 pages and missing content

The missing page most business owners notice first is the 404 page. This usually appears when someone tries to visit a page that can no longer be found at that web address. In plain English, the website has been asked for something that is not there anymore, or at least not there in the way the link expects. That may sound minor, but it can have a bigger effect on trust than many owners realise.

A 404 can happen for several reasons. A page may have been deleted on purpose. It may have been renamed during a redesign. A link may have been typed incorrectly. An old blog post may still point to content that has since been removed. Sometimes the problem is harmless and easy to fix. Sometimes it affects an important page that visitors rely on, such as a service page, contact page, booking page, or download.

What makes 404s frustrating is not only the error itself. It is the interruption. A visitor was trying to get somewhere useful and instead hit a dead end. That breaks the flow of the journey and can make the website feel neglected, even if the rest of the site looks professional. It can also create doubt at exactly the wrong moment, especially if someone was close to making contact.

A missing page does not always mean the content needs to come back exactly as it was. In some cases, the right answer is to update the link, redirect visitors to a better replacement, or improve the journey around that missing page. The important thing is not to leave people stranded. A clear next step can make a much better impression than an abrupt stop.

Quick 404 checklist:

- [ ] Check whether the page was removed by accident
- [ ] Update old links if the page was renamed
- [ ] Send visitors to a relevant replacement if one exists
- [ ] Review important pages first, such as services and contact
- [ ] Do not leave high-traffic errors sitting unnoticed

A website health report can help you separate small tidy-up jobs from the missing pages that matter most. The goal is not to panic every time a 404 appears. It is to know which missing pages are harmless, which ones need a quick fix, and which ones could be costing you trust or enquiries.

03

Redirects and old URLs

Not every broken link means a page has disappeared forever. Sometimes the content still exists, but under a different web address. That is where redirects come in. A redirect sends visitors from an old URL to a newer, more relevant one automatically, so they do not land on an error page. For a small business site, this often happens after a redesign, a tidy-up of service pages, or a change to blog post URLs.

Redirects are useful because they help preserve the journey. If someone clicks an older link in Google, an email, or a saved bookmark, they can still reach the content they were trying to find. When redirects are set up well, most visitors will not even notice them. They will simply arrive on the right page and carry on. That smooth handover is what makes redirects so valuable when website content has moved.

Problems begin when redirects are handled badly. Some websites send every old page to the homepage, which can feel confusing and unhelpful. Others create redirect chains, where one old address sends visitors through several extra steps before they finally land somewhere useful. In more serious cases, redirect loops trap the browser in a circle and the page never loads properly at all.

This matters because old URLs can continue circulating long after you have changed the site. They may still appear in search results, on social media, in old newsletters, or on another website that linked to you months ago. If those older addresses still guide people somewhere useful, the experience feels smooth. If they do not, visitors may assume the content has disappeared completely.

Good redirect habits:

- [ ] Send visitors to the closest matching new page
- [ ] Avoid sending unrelated pages to the homepage
- [ ] Keep the journey short and direct
- [ ] Review older URLs after site changes
- [ ] Fix loops or chains before they build up

The simplest way to think about redirects is as signposts. Good signposts keep people moving without fuss. Poor signposts waste time, break confidence, and make the website feel harder to use. That is why redirects belong in any sensible website audit for small business, especially after pages have been moved or renamed.

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Broken images and missing files

When people think about broken links, they often picture a text link that leads to an error page. But some of the most noticeable problems on a website are not text links at all. They are missing images, broken downloads, dead buttons, or files that no longer open. These issues can be just as damaging because they make the website feel incomplete, outdated, or poorly maintained.

A broken image might leave a blank space where something important should appear. A missing PDF might stop someone accessing your brochure, price list, or guide. A button might promise a download, booking page, or contact step, only to lead nowhere. Even if the rest of the page looks fine, that single failure can change how professional the whole site feels. Small visual or file errors often make a website feel older than it really is.

These issues are especially important on small business websites because they often sit close to decision-making points. A visitor may be trying to view a menu, open a case study, download useful information, or click a button that moves them closer to an enquiry. If that moment breaks, trust can drop very quickly. In many cases, people will not complain. They will simply leave and try someone else.

That is one reason these issues are easy to underestimate. They do not always create a dramatic error page, so they can look less serious at first glance. But they often fail at exactly the moment a visitor wants reassurance, detail, or proof that the business is organised. When that support material is missing, the whole website can feel less dependable than it should.

What to test on your website:

- [ ] Main page images and banners
- [ ] Brochures, menus, and PDF downloads
- [ ] Contact, booking, and enquiry buttons
- [ ] Older blog posts with linked files
- [ ] Embedded forms, maps, or documents

A strong website health check service should include these checks, not just page-level errors. Visitors do not think in technical categories. They only notice whether the website works smoothly and feels finished. That is why broken images and missing files belong in the same conversation as broken links, 404s, and redirects.

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A simple monthly link-check mindset

Broken links are rarely caused by one big mistake. More often, they appear through ordinary website changes that happen over time. A page gets renamed. A service is removed. A brochure is updated. A blog post links to something that later disappears. Each change feels small on its own, but together they can create a website that is harder to trust and harder to use than it once was.

That is why the best mindset is not panic. It is routine. A simple monthly check helps you treat link health as basic website housekeeping rather than a technical emergency. You do not need to inspect every inch of the site every week. You just need a calm, repeatable habit that helps you catch obvious issues before visitors do. This is especially useful if your website is updated in small bursts rather than managed every day.

This matters most for busy owners who already have plenty to think about. If website checks only happen when something goes badly wrong, small problems can sit unnoticed for months. A monthly website report or website monitoring report changes that. It gives you a clearer picture of what needs attention and makes it easier to deal with issues while they are still manageable. That can remove a lot of guesswork from website maintenance.d

A routine like this also makes website care feel more realistic. You do not need specialist knowledge or hours of spare time to stay on top of the basics. You just need a habit of checking the areas that matter most. That small amount of consistency can be enough to catch the kinds of issues that quietly chip away at trust long before they grow into bigger problems.

Monthly routine:

- [ ] Click your main menu and footer links
- [ ] Test your contact page and core buttons
- [ ] Open key downloads and important files
- [ ] Review recently updated pages
- [ ] Check one or two older blog posts

This kind of routine will not make your website perfect overnight, but it does make it more dependable. Over time, that consistency protects trust, reduces surprises, and helps your website support the business more reliably. For many small businesses, that steady approach is far more realistic than an occasional major audit.

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How SiteScanly can help

If all of this feels like one more task on an already full list, that is exactly where SiteScanly can help. SiteScanly is designed for small business owners and sole traders who want clear answers without technical jargon. Instead of leaving you to piece together information from several different tools, it brings key website issues into one plain-English view so you can see what matters and what to do next.

That matters because finding a broken link is only part of the job. What most owners really need to know is whether the issue is minor or important, whether it affects trust or enquiries, and whether it should be fixed now or later. A raw technical scan rarely answers those questions in a useful way. A clearer website health report does. It helps turn technical noise into practical next steps.

For link-related issues, SiteScanly helps turn scattered technical signals into something more practical. It can show where there are problems with missing pages, link paths, page responses, or files that are no longer working as expected. Just as importantly, it explains those findings in a way that makes sense to non-technical business owners. That is what gives it a done-for-you website audit feel without overwhelming you.

This is particularly helpful for owners who rely on their website to bring in leads but do not want to spend time interpreting technical reports. Instead of being left with a confusing list of faults, you get clearer context around what each issue means. That makes it easier to decide what needs fixing first and what can wait until later without second-guessing every result.

SiteScanly can help spot:

- Broken internal links
- Broken external links
- 404s and missing pages
- Redirect issues
- Broken images and missing files

That means you spend less time guessing and less time reacting when a customer spots something first. Instead, you get a website health check that is easier to understand and easier to act on each month. For a busy owner, that can make monthly website care feel much calmer, more consistent, and far more manageable.

SiteScanly

Interested in a monthly website health report?

Go to sitescanly.com

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